# Preface

## To the Reader

In late 1995, the Java programming language burst onto the Internet scene and gained instant celebrity status. The promise of Java technology was that it would become the *universal glue* that connects users with information wherever it comes from—web servers, databases, information providers, or any other imaginable source. Indeed, Java is in a unique position to fulfill this promise. It is an extremely solidly engineered language that has gained wide acceptance. Its built-in security and safety features are reassuring both to programmers and to the users of Java programs. Java has built-in support for advanced programming tasks, such as network programming, database connectivity, and concurrency.

Since 1995, over twenty revisions of the Java Development Kit have been released. The Application Programming Interface (API) has grown from about a hundred to over 4,000 classes. The API now spans such diverse areas as concurrent programming, collections, user interface construction, database management, internationalization, security, and XML processing.

The book that you are reading right now is the first volume of the thirteenth edition of *Core Java*. Each edition closely followed a release of the Java Development Kit, and each time, I rewrote the book to take advantage of the newest Java features. This edition has been updated to reflect the features of Java 21.

As with the previous editions, *this book still targets serious programmers who want to put Java to work on real projects.* I think of you, the reader, as a programmer with a solid background in a programming language other than Java. I assume that you don't like books filled with toy examples (such as toasters, zoo animals, or "nervous text"). You won't find any of these in the book. My goal is to enable you to fully understand the Java language and library, not to give you an illusion of understanding.

In this book you will find lots of sample code demonstrating almost every language and library feature. The sample programs are purposefully simple to focus on the major points, but, for the most part, they aren't fake and they don't cut corners. They should make good starting points for your own code.

I assume you are willing, even eager, to learn about all the features that the Java language puts at your disposal. In this volume, you will find a detailed treatment of

- Object-oriented programming
- Reflection and proxies
- Interfaces and inner classes
- Exception handling
- Generic programming
- The collections framework
- Concurrency
- Annotations
- The Java platform module system

With the explosive growth of the Java class library, a one-volume treatment of all the features of Java that serious programmers need to know is simply not possible. Hence, the book is broken up into two volumes. This first volume concentrates on the fundamental concepts of the Java language. The second volume, *Core Java, Volume II: Advanced Features*, goes further into the most important libraries.

For twelve editions, user-interface programming was considered fundamental, but the time has come to recognize that it is no more, and to move it into the second volume. That volume includes detailed discussions of these topics:

- The Stream API
- File processing and regular expressions
- Databases
- XML processing
- Scripting and Compiling APIs
- Internationalization
- Network programming
- Graphical user interface design
- Graphics programming
- Native methods

When writing a book, errors and inaccuracies are inevitable. I'd very much like to know about them. But, of course, I'd prefer to learn about each of them only once. You will find a list of frequently asked questions and bug fixes at **https://horstmann.com/corejava**. Strategically placed at the end of the errata page (to encourage you to read through it first) is a form you can use to report bugs and sug-

gest improvements. Please don't be disappointed if I don't answer every query or don't get back to you immediately. I do read all e-mail and appreciate your input to make future editions of this book clearer and more informative.

## A Tour of This Book

**Chapter 1** gives an overview of the capabilities of Java that set it apart from other programming languages. The chapter explains what the designers of the language set out to do and to what extent they succeeded. A short history of Java follows, detailing how Java came into being and how it has evolved.

In **Chapter 2**, you will see how to download and install the JDK and the program examples for this book. Then I'll guide you through compiling and running a console application and a graphical application. You will see how to use the plain JDK, a Java IDE, and the JShell tool.

**Chapter 3** starts the discussion of the Java language. In this chapter, I cover the basics: variables, loops, and simple functions. If you are a C or C++ programmer, this is smooth sailing because the syntax for these language features is essentially the same as in C. If you come from a non-C background such as Visual Basic, you will want to read this chapter carefully.

Object-oriented programming (OOP) is now in the mainstream of programming practice, and Java is an object-oriented programming language. **Chapter 4** introduces encapsulation, the first of two fundamental building blocks of object orientation, and the Java language mechanism to implement it—that is, classes and methods. In addition to the rules of the Java language, you will also find advice on sound OOP design. Finally, I cover the marvelous `javadoc` tool that formats your code comments as a set of hyperlinked web pages. If you are familiar with C++, you can browse through this chapter quickly. Programmers coming from a non-object-oriented background should expect to spend some time mastering the OOP concepts before going further with Java.

Classes and encapsulation are only one part of the OOP story, and **Chapter 5** introduces the other—namely, *inheritance*. Inheritance lets you take an existing class and modify it according to your needs. This is a fundamental technique for programming in Java. The inheritance mechanism in Java is quite similar to that in C++. Once again, C++ programmers can focus on the differences between the languages.

**Chapter 6** shows you how to use Java's notion of an *interface*. Interfaces let you go beyond the simple inheritance model of **Chapter 5**. Mastering interfaces allows you to have full access to the power of Java's completely object-oriented approach to programming. After covering interfaces, I move on to *lambda expressions*, a concise way for expressing a block of code that can be executed at a later point in time. I then explain a useful technical feature of Java called *inner classes*.

**Chapter 7** discusses *exception handling*—Java's robust mechanism to deal with the fact that bad things can happen to good programs. Exceptions give you an efficient way of separating the normal processing code from the error handling. Of course, even after hardening your program by handling all exceptional conditions, it still might fail to work as expected. Then the chapter moves on to logging. In the final part of this chapter, I give you a number of useful debugging tips.

**Chapter 8** gives an overview of generic programming. Generic programming makes your programs easier to read and safer. I show you how to use strong typing and remove unsightly and unsafe casts, and how to deal with the complexities that arise from the need to stay compatible with older versions of Java.

The topic of **Chapter 9** is the collections framework of the Java platform. Whenever you want to collect multiple objects and retrieve them later, you should use a collection that is best suited for your circumstances, instead of just tossing the elements into an array. This chapter shows you how to take advantage of the standard collections that are prebuilt for your use.

**Chapter 10** covers concurrency, which enables you to program tasks to be done in parallel. This is an important and exciting application of Java technology in an era where processors have multiple cores that you want to keep busy.

In **Chapter 11**, you will learn about annotations, which allow you to add arbitrary information (sometimes called metadata) to a Java program. We show you how annotation processors can harvest these annotations at the source or class file level, and how annotations can be used to influence the behavior of classes at runtime. Annotations are only useful with tools, and we hope that our discussion will help you select useful annotation processing tools for your needs.

In **Chapter 12**, you will learn about the Java Platform Module System that facilitates an orderly evolution of the Java platform and core libraries. This module system provides encapsulation for packages and a mechanism for describing module requirements. You

will learn the properties of modules so that you can decide whether to use them in your own applications. Even if you decide not to, you need to know the new rules so that you can interact with the Java platform and other modularized libraries.

The **Appendix** lists the reserved words of the Java language.

## Conventions

As is common in many computer books, I use `monospace type` to represent computer code.

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**Note:** Notes are tagged with "note" icons that look like this.

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**Tip:** Tips are tagged with "tip" icons that look like this.

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**Caution:** When there is danger ahead, I warn you with a "caution" icon.

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**Preview Note:** Preview features that are slated to become a part of the language or API in the future are labeled with this icon.

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**C++ Note:** There are many C++ notes that explain the differences between Java and C++. You can skip over them if you don't have a background in C++ or if you consider your experience with that language a bad dream of which you'd rather not be reminded.

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Java comes with a large programming library, or Application Programming Interface (API). When using an API call for the first time, I add a short summary description at the end of the section. These descriptions are a bit more informal but, hopefully, also a little more informative than those in the official online API documentation. The names of interfaces are in italics, just like in the official documentation. The number after a class, interface, or method name is the JDK version in which the feature was introduced, as shown in the following example:

```
Application Programming Interface 21
```

Programs whose source code is on the book's companion web site are presented as listings, for instance:

**Listing NotHelloWorld.java**

```
1 void main()
2 {
3   System.out.println("We will not use 'Hello, World!'");
4 }
```

## Sample Code

The web site for this book at **https://horstmann.com/corejava** contains all sample code from the book. See **Chapter 2** for more information on installing the Java Development Kit and the sample code.

Previous chapter

‹ Core Java, Volume I: Fundamentals, 13th Edition

Next chapter

Acknowledgments ›